The House of Mourning

By Kate Braestrup

KATE: **(Pg 27-32)** Nina's mother came up to me, and she said . . . .

NINA'S MOM: Chaplain, I think I have a problem. It's Nina. She says she wants to go and see Andy, her cousin.

KATE: Well, I looked over at Nina, who was hanging by her knees from the swing set in her backyard, little pigtails brushing the ground. *(to Nina's Mom)* How old is Nina, again?

NINA'S MOM: Five.

KATE: Wow. *(to audience)* I should probably mention that cousin Andy was dead.

INTRODUCTION

It has been said that if you are old enough to love, you are old enough to grieve. Children as young as five are aware of the concept of death. They hear about it in fairy tales, see it in shows and movies – some children may have already experienced the death of a pet.

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But what advice do you give to a parent in this situation? Is a child of five ready to enter . . .

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KATE: I've been chaplain to the Maine Warden Service for about thirteen years now. And in Maine game wardens enforce fish and wildlife law. But they also respond to a whole variety of outdoor calamities: snowmobile accidents, freshwater drownings, all-terrain-vehicle accidents. And when they think the outcome is likely to be fatal, they ask their chaplain to go along.

And I also teach game wardens in the academy how to support bereaved people. The example I usually use is personal.

My first husband, a state trooper, was killed in the line of duty. He died instantly when his cruiser was T-boned by a truck. As soon as I was told that fact, I knew I wanted to see him and take care of him. So I told the funeral director, and [he] responded using a special voice that I think funeral directors learn in school.

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FUNERAL DIRECTOR: Yes. I understand.

KATE: And then he went back to the funeral parlor, and he called the Maine State Police.

FUNERAL DIRECTOR: I think you should know that your trooper's widow wants to see and dress and take care of the body herself.

KATE: And the state police freaked out. All night long, phone calls were ricocheting back and forth between the state police, the funeral parlor and Tom, the trooper who had been specifically assigned to manage me.

In the morning Tom arrived, and he said,

TOM: Kate, we're gonna let you do this thing. But you have to take me with you. And we're going to bring Sergeant Drake and Sergeant Cunningham along as well. If we don't like what we see, we're going to take you out.

KATE: And I pictured three troopers all drawing their sidearms and taking aim in the funeral parlor. I said, "I think it's gonna be okay." Mom was reassuring.

KATE'S MOM: *(To Tom)* You know, she grew up on a farm. She's used to dead things. *(Pause)*

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KATE: I had to fake absolute confidence in this because I'd never done this before. But I faked it. I took my mother by the hand, and she and I, surrounded by troopers, did a weird sort of perp walk up the street to the funeral parlor. They were all watching me as I walked into this cool room where Drew's body lay. *(Long pause)* And it was okay. ***I*** was okay.

I had about twenty minutes alone with my husband's body. Then they all came back, and we got him dressed in his dress uniform.

And it was hard. (I mean, if you've ever tried to get someone into a Class-A uniform when they're not cooperating, you know what I mean.) But it was fine. Actually, it was better than fine. It was actually kind of great. It was beautiful and sad and funny, and it was okay. *(Pause)*

But there are [those] who need a less personal, more biblical example. So, I remind them that Mary Magdalene went to see and touch and anoint the body of Jesus, and she didn't have to overcome the protective skepticism of the disciples to do that. When she got to the tomb and found it empty, she

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didn't have to justify her distress at finding the body gone.

Nowadays we're persuaded that it's the presence of the body, not its absence, that is most distressing. But in my experience -- and I have a lot of experience by now -- people are far more likely to regret not having seen the body than they are to wish they hadn't.

So, we're actually training our wardens to make space for the family to be with the body. Give them a moment where all the strangers and officials get out of the way and let them take care of their own. And let me tell you, the mourners are (pause) brave and (pause) tender. A mother will smooth the hair back from her drowned son's forehead, and the dad will hold his hand. A spouse will bring a flower and put it on his breast and murmur endearments. They're beautiful. *(Pause)*

But okay. Nina was five. She was five. And her cousin, her best friend Andy. . . was *four.*

Nina -- she didn't grow up on a farm. Maybe there's a dead goldfish in her background

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somewhere. But if you're five, there's not a lot of background to work with.

Suffer the little children to come unto me. That was this biblical phrase that kept going around in my head. Although, the one good thing you could say about Andy's death was that he didn't suffer. He was killed instantly when an all-terrain vehicle driven by a neighbor rolled over on him.

When we had cleared the scene that day, they had taken his body to a funeral parlor, and that was where Nina wanted to go, to visit him. Her dad said . . .

NINA'S DAD: We want to protect her.

NINA'S MOM: I know, but she's so sure.

KATE: And finally, I said *(to Nina's parents)* You know, you're her parents. You know her. You know what's right for her much better than I do. But I do believe it would be okay. I believe it would not hurt her more to see him.

(to audience) So, three days later, I went back up to this little town, because Andy's family had asked me to preside over the service. I got to the church

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a little early, and Nina's mom was there, and she was arranging stuff on the altar table -- photographs and Tonka trucks and teddy bears, flowers. *(To Nina's Mom)* So, did Nina go see Andy?

NINA'S MOM: Let me tell you . . . Got in the car, drove her to the funeral parlor. Soon as we pull in, Nina's out of the car, striding across the parking lot. We had to scramble to keep up with her. She goes in through the front door, past the funeral-parlor guy.

And we stopped her at the door of the cool room. *(to Nina)* Nina, we just want to make sure that you understand that Andy's not gonna be able to talk to you.

NINA: Yup.

NINA'S MOM: Well, and you understand, he's not gonna move or get up.

NINA: Yeah, yeah.

KATE: *(takes over the story telling)* And she opened the door, and in she went, and she walked right up to the dais where Andy's body lay, covered by a quilt that his mom had made for him when he was a baby.

She walked right up to him, putting her hands on him to make sure he was all there. Then she put her head down on his chest and talked to him. After about ten minutes of this, her parents were awash in tears, and they'd kind of had enough, so they said, "Nina, you ready to go?"

NINA: No. I'll tell you when I am.

KATE: So, she sang him a song, and she put his Fisher-Price plastic telescope in his hand, so that he could see anyone he wanted to see from heaven. And then she was okay, and she was done.

NINA: But he's not gonna be getting up again, so I have to tuck him in.

KATE: So, she walked all the way around the dais, tucking in the quilt. And then she put her hand on him and said,

NINA: I love you, Andy Dandy. Good-bye. *(Long pause)*

KATE: You can trust a human being with grief. *(Pause)* Walk fearlessly into the house of mourning, for grief is just love squaring up to its oldest enemy. And after all these mortal human years, love is up

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to the challenge. *(Pause)*

I don't have to fake confidence in this anymore, because I have Nina. And now, with the gracious permission of Nina's family, so do you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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